we did was primarily to improve operational efficiency; everything else was secondary. There would be advantages and disadvantages, gainers and losers, but that had to be taken in its stride. The Human Resource (HR) aspect could not become the driving factor. When I pointed out that there were already a number of Independent Brigades in existence, which report directly to the Corps, the idea gradually started to sink in. Moreover, since each IBG (as also Independent Brigades) would be commanded by a Maj Gen, it would also improve the promotion prospects at this level. It was also emphasized that this transition was not going to happen overnight but as part of a deliberate process. When Mohanty and I had worked on this in Eastern Command, we had estimated that it might take a Corps up to two years to make this change. This was enough time to make mid-course corrections, if required. Since operational balance would have to be maintained, not all Corps would restructure simultaneously. Even working at an optimistic figure of two Corps per year, it would still take a decade for the change to take effect.

This might sound unbelievable at first glance but that is not so. Take the case of the PLA, who have a concept of Combined Arms Brigade (CAB), which is fundamentally the same as our IBG. The change from Division to CABs in the PLA started sometime in the early 2000s and is still ongoing. When the PLA mobilized opposite us in Eastern Ladakh, regular Divisions as well as CABs were identified. Since the changeover in our case would also take years, it would automatically allow various HR issues to be addressed. This process, being called the IBG-ization of the Indian Army, is now underway. From the time it was first ideated in 2018 to its test-bedding in 2020, to its roll-out in 2022 has been a long journey.[4] Consolidation and Change go hand in hand.

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